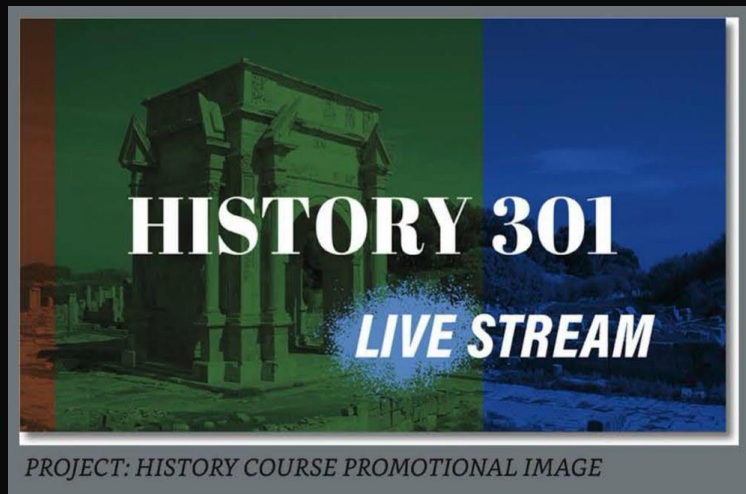


Building a Promotional Graphic

You will build a professional 1920 × 1080 pixel live stream promotional image from scratch.

You will learn to use Layers, the Rectangular Marquee selection tool, the Type tool, Adjustment Layers, the Brush tool, Generative Fill, and the Export As command.



The finished graphic you will build in this lesson

Steps in this lesson:

1. New Document

2. Place Photo

3. Set Units

4. New Layer

5. Orange Bar

6. Blue Bar

7. Color Blend Mode

8. Title Text

9. Subtitle Text

10. Solid Color Layer

11. Sample + Paint

12. Move + Gen Fill

13. Export

Create a New Document

A Photoshop document is called a PSD file. It stores every layer, mask, and adjustment you make — all in one file. Your final deliverable is a 1920 × 1080 pixel canvas, which is the standard size for HD video and live stream graphics.

1

Choose File > New

This opens the New Document dialog. You can also click New File on the Home screen.

2

Click the Film & Video category

Look at the row of tabs across the top of the dialog — Photo, Print, Art & Illustration, Film & Video, etc. Click Film & Video.

3

Click the HDTV 1080p preset

This sets the canvas to exactly 1920 px wide and 1080 px tall at 72 pixels per inch. The Preset Details panel on the right confirms the settings. HDTV 1080p is the broadcast and streaming standard.

4

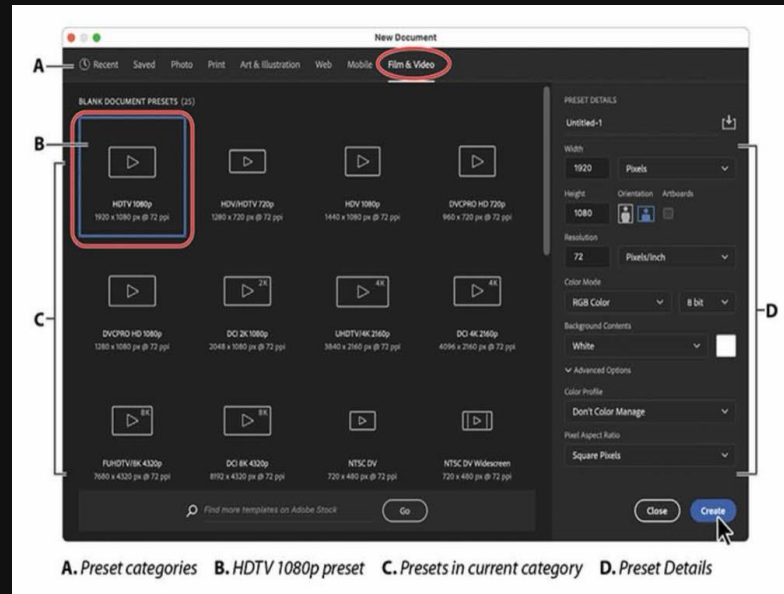
Click Create

A new blank canvas opens. Photoshop adds cyan guide lines automatically — these mark the safe zone where important content should stay.

5

File > Save As — name it 01Working.psd

Save immediately as a PSD file so you have a working copy to build on. Click OK or Save when the dialog appears.



New Document dialog — Film & Video tab, HDTV 1080p highlighted (PDF p.6)

Place the Photo — File > Place Embedded

Place Embedded copies the photo file into your PSD document as a Smart Object. A Smart Object preserves the original image data so you can resize, rotate, or transform it without permanently losing quality.

1

Choose File > Place Embedded

Navigate to your Lesson01 folder. Select Arch.jpg. Click Place.

2

A bounding box with handles appears around the photo

The photo is placed but not yet committed. You can see the Transform handles at each corner and the midpoints of each edge. A diagonal X shows the layer boundary.

3

Drag a corner handle to resize the image

Click and drag any corner handle outward so the photo covers the full width of the canvas. The image will scale proportionally. To reposition, click and drag anywhere inside the bounding box (not on a handle).

4

Click the checkmark ✓ in the options bar to commit

The checkmark is at the far right end of the options bar at the very top of Photoshop. You can also press Enter or Return. The bounding box disappears and the Arch layer appears in the Layers panel.



Arch.jpg placed on canvas — bounding box handles visible at corners and edges (PDF p.7)

Set Units to Pixels — One-Time Setup

Photoshop measures distances and sizes in whatever unit is currently set. For screen and video work you always want Pixels. If your ruler or info panel is showing inches or centimeters you will not get accurate measurements when you draw your selection.

1 Windows: Edit > Preferences > Units & Rulers macOS: Photoshop > Settings > Units & Rulers

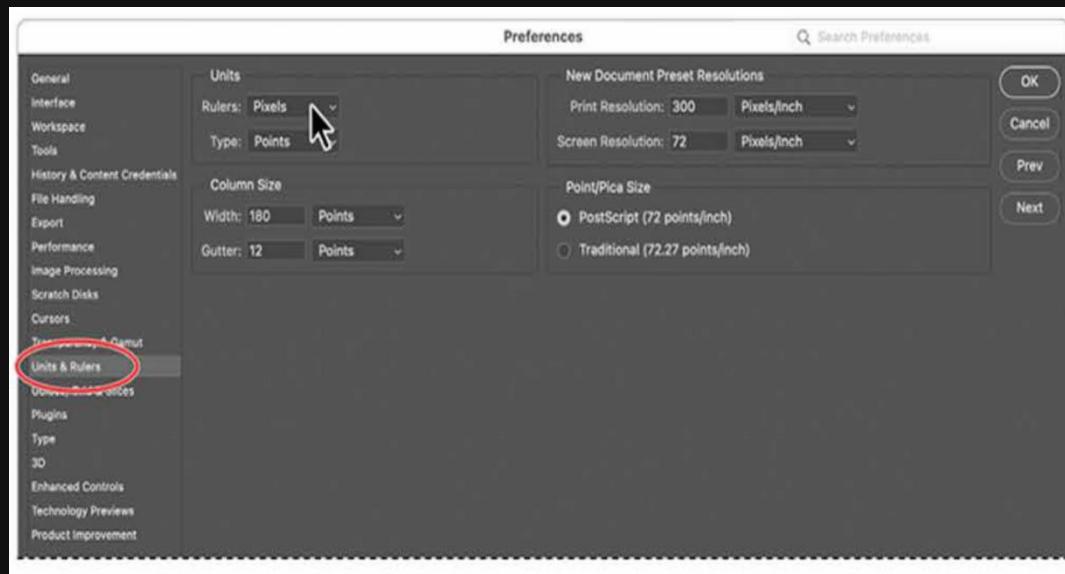
Both paths open the same Preferences dialog box.

2 In the Units section, set Rulers to Pixels

Look for the Units section at the top of the panel. Click the Rulers dropdown and choose Pixels.

3 Click OK

This setting stays until you change it. You only need to do this once on this computer.



⚠ Why this matters: In the next step you will draw a rectangle that needs to be exactly 96 pixels wide. If your units are set to inches, the info indicator will show inches and you will not know when you hit the right size.

Create a New Layer — Name It Rectangles

Layers are the foundation of Photoshop. Think of each layer like a clear sheet of film stacked on top of the others. You will draw the colored bars on a separate layer from the photo so you can edit them independently at any time — without touching or changing the original Arch photo.

1 In the Layers panel, click the Arch layer to select it

New layers are always created directly above the currently selected layer. Clicking Arch first ensures the Rectangles layer lands in the right position in the stack.

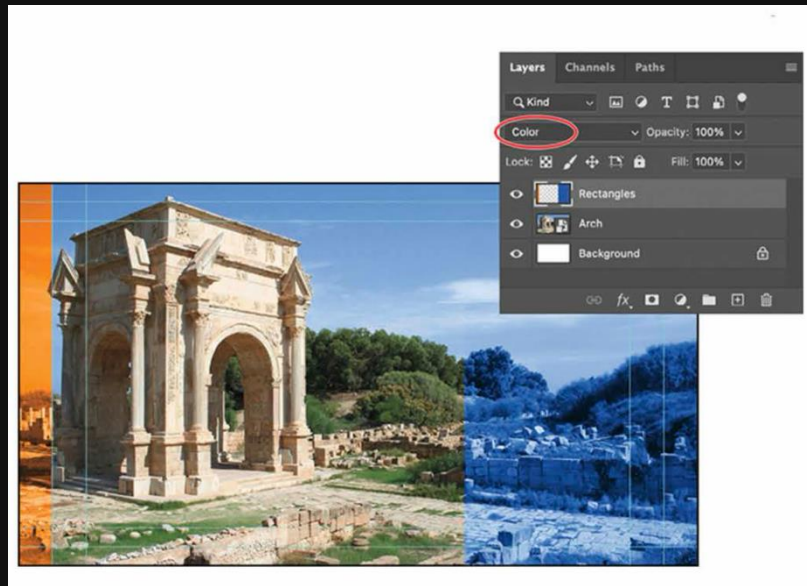
2 Click the Create a New Layer button

The button is at the bottom of the Layers panel — it looks like a square with a folded corner. A new empty transparent layer appears above Arch.

3 Double-click the new layer name in the Layers panel

It will say Layer 1 by default. Double-click directly on the name text. Type Rectangles and press Enter or Return. Good layer naming is a professional habit.

💡 **Industry Habit:** Name every layer as you create it. On real client projects a document can have 50+ layers. Clear names save you hours of hunting.



Draw the Orange Bar — Select the Rectangular Marquee Tool

The Rectangular Marquee tool creates a selection — a defined area of pixels marked by a dotted border called "marching ants." Any edit you make (like filling with color) will only affect the pixels inside the selection. This is how you paint inside the lines in Photoshop.

1 Make sure the Rectangles layer is selected in the Layers panel

Whatever layer is highlighted in the Layers panel is the one you will paint or draw on. Confirm Rectangles is selected before you draw anything.

2 Select the Rectangular Marquee tool — press M or click the icon in the Tools panel

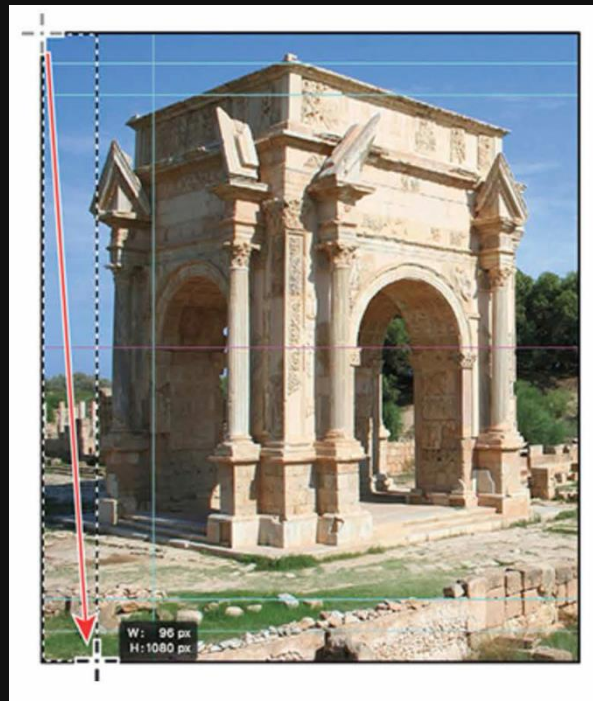
The Tools panel runs along the left edge of the screen. The Rectangular Marquee tool looks like a dotted rectangle. Press the keyboard shortcut M to grab it instantly.

3 Drag from just outside the upper-left corner of the canvas, straight down

Start your drag just slightly off the canvas edge (to the upper-left). Drag down and to the right. Watch the live info indicator near your cursor — it shows the Width and Height of your selection as you drag.

4 Release when the info indicator reads W: 96px and H: 1080px

The selection should snap to the canvas edge and run the full height of the canvas. A dotted marquee border appears around the selected area. If you missed the size, press Ctrl+D (Win) or Cmd+D (Mac) to deselect and try again.



Fill the Orange Bar with Color

1 In the Contextual Task Bar, click Fill Selection

The Contextual Task Bar is the floating bar that appears near your selection on the canvas. Click the Fill Selection button, then choose Fill Color from the dropdown menu that appears.

2 The Color Picker dialog opens — type ff7f00 in the # field

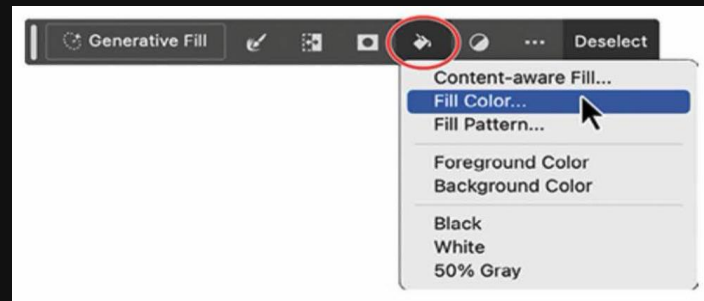
Look for the small # symbol near the bottom of the Color Picker. Click in that field and type ff7f00. This is a hexadecimal color code — a 6-digit code used in design and web work to define exact colors. ff7f00 is the orange you need.

3 Click OK to close the Color Picker, then click OK again to close the Fill dialog

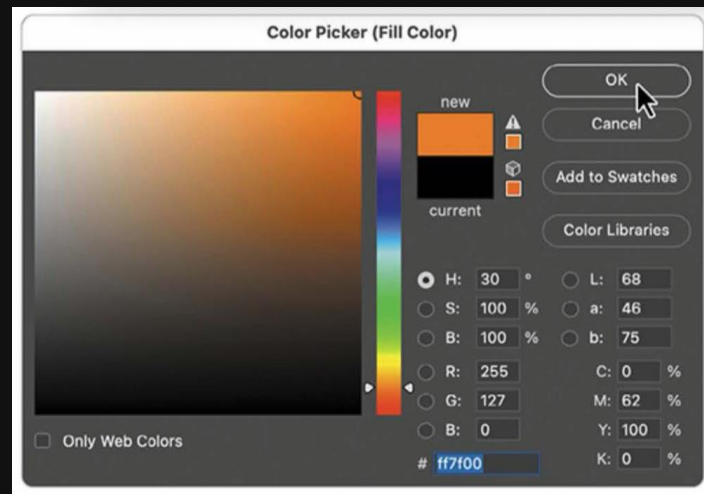
The orange color fills your 96px selection on the Rectangles layer.

4 Choose Select > Deselect — or press Ctrl+D (Win) / Cmd+D (Mac)

This removes the marching ants selection border. The orange bar stays. Your canvas should now show a vertical orange stripe along the left edge.



Contextual Task Bar — Fill Selection > Fill Color



Color Picker — type ff7f00 in the # field

Draw the Blue Bar — Make the Selection

You are still working on the Rectangles layer with the Rectangular Marquee tool. This second rectangle uses Edit > Fill instead of the Contextual Task Bar — both methods fill a selection with color, just from different menus.

1 Confirm the Rectangles layer is still selected in the Layers panel

Look at the Layers panel on the right. Rectangles should still be highlighted. If not, click it to select it.

2 Drag from just outside the upper-right corner of the canvas, down and to the left

Start your drag just slightly off the canvas edge at the top-right corner. Drag down and to the left toward the center of the canvas.

3 Release when the info indicator reads W: 660px and H: 1080px

The selection runs the full height of the canvas on the right side. If you missed the size, press Ctrl+D (Win) / Cmd+D (Mac) to deselect and redraw.

4 Choose Edit > Fill

This opens the Fill dialog box. Click the Contents dropdown and choose Color. The Color Picker opens.

5 Type 0053b2 in the # field — click OK, then OK again

0053b2 is a vivid blue hex code. The blue fills the rectangular selection on the right side of your canvas.



Apply the Color Blend Mode to the Rectangles Layer

1 Choose Select > Deselect — or press Ctrl+D / Cmd+D

The marching ants selection disappears. You should now see a solid orange bar on the left and a solid blue bar on the right over the photo.

2 In the Layers panel, find the blending mode dropdown — it currently says Normal

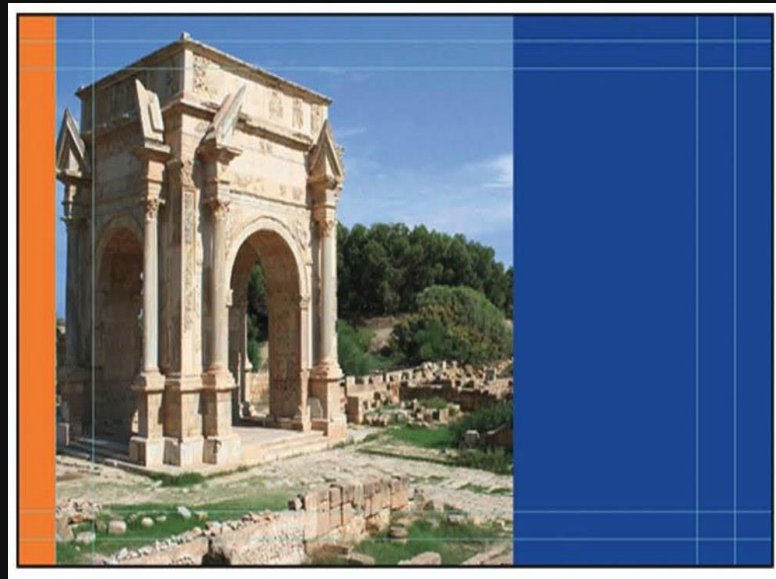
This dropdown is at the top-left of the Layers panel, just above your layer list. It controls how the colors on this layer interact with the layers below it.

3 Click the dropdown and choose Color

The blending mode changes to Color. The photo (Arch layer) now shows through both bars. The Color blending mode keeps the luminosity — the light and dark values — from the layer below, and applies only the hue and saturation from the Rectangles layer. This creates a tinted look instead of a solid block of color.

4 Choose File > Save — or press Ctrl+S / Cmd+S

Save your progress. Always save after completing a major step.



Canvas showing orange and blue Color-blended bars over the Arch photo



Blend Modes: A blend mode tells Photoshop a mathematical formula for how pixels on one layer mix with pixels on the layer below. Color blend mode is one of over 27 available blend modes. You will explore more in future lessons.

Add the Title Text — Set Up the Type Tool

Type in Photoshop lives on its own Type layer. When you click the canvas with the Type tool, Photoshop automatically creates a new layer for that text. You set your font, size, alignment, and color in the options bar before you click and type.

1

Select the Horizontal Type tool — press T or click the T icon in the Tools panel

The options bar across the top of Photoshop now shows type options: font family, style, size, alignment buttons, and a color swatch.

2

Choose a font — the book uses Abril Fatface (Adobe Fonts)

Click the font name field in the options bar and type Abril Fatface, then press Enter. If you do not have this font, any heavy bold serif display font works. The key is a strong, readable typeface.

3

Set the font size to 210 pt

Click the size field in the options bar and type 210, then press Enter. Points (pt) are the standard unit for measuring type size.

4

Click the Center Text alignment button in the options bar

The three alignment buttons are in the options bar — left align, center, and right align. Choose Center Text.

5

Click the color swatch in the options bar and set color to pure white — type ffffff

Type ffffff in the # field of the Color Picker that opens and click OK. White text will read clearly against the colored and tinted photo background.

3. Specify 210 pt for the font size.



Type tool options bar — font, size, alignment buttons, color swatch labeled

Enable All Caps and Type the Title Text

6 Enable the All Caps type option in the Properties panel

With the Type tool selected, scroll down in the Properties panel on the right until you see the Type Options section. Click the TT (All Caps) button. This automatically makes every letter a capital — so you do not have to hold Shift or use Caps Lock while typing.

7 Click approximately in the lower-center of the canvas

A new Type layer is created automatically. You will see placeholder Lorem Ipsum text appear selected in blue. This is normal — it shows your current type settings as a preview.

8 Type: History 301

Because All Caps is active, the text appears as HISTORY 301 even though you type in lowercase. The text replaces the Lorem Ipsum placeholder automatically as you begin typing.

9 Click the checkmark ✓ in the options bar to commit

Committing exits type editing mode. You can also press Ctrl+Enter (Win) or Cmd+Return (Mac). Do not press just Enter/Return — that adds a line break in the text.

10 If the text is not centered, select the Move tool (V) and drag it

Press V to switch to the Move tool. Click and drag the text layer on the canvas to center it horizontally. Smart Guides — the pink magenta lines that appear — will snap to the center of the canvas to help you align it.



Add the Subtitle Text — Live Stream

This second line of text gets its own Type layer with different settings — a different font, smaller size, and right-aligned. You must deselect the existing type layer first so Photoshop creates a new one.

1

Choose Select > Deselect Layers

This deselects the History 301 type layer. If you skip this step and click on the canvas, Photoshop may add to the existing layer instead of creating a new one.

2

With the Type tool still active, change the font to a condensed style

The book uses Acumin Pro Condensed Black Italic (Adobe Fonts). Any narrow, condensed bold-italic font works. Change the font in the options bar font field.

3

Change the size to 165 pt and click the Right Align Text button

This text will anchor to the right side of the canvas. Right alignment makes it read naturally next to the right edge guide.

4

Click near the right guide, two-thirds down from the top, and type: Live Stream

Because All Caps is still active from the previous step, LIVE STREAM will appear. Position the click point roughly between the History 301 text and the bottom of the canvas, near the right inner guide line.

5

Click the checkmark ✓ to commit

A second Type layer called Live Stream (or LIVE STREAM) now appears in the Layers panel above the History 301 layer.



Canvas with both text layers — HISTORY 301 centered, LIVE STREAM right-aligned below

Add a Solid Color Adjustment Layer — Dark Green

The white text is currently hard to read against the lighter parts of the Arch photo. You need to add a dark, semi-transparent layer of green over the photo to improve contrast. You could fill a regular pixel layer with green, but a Solid Color Fill Layer is smarter — its color can be edited at any time simply by double-clicking its thumbnail in the Layers panel. No redoing steps.

1 In the Layers panel, click the Arch layer to select it

The Solid Color layer must be created above Arch but below the Rectangles and text layers. Selecting Arch first puts the new layer in exactly the right position in the stack.

2 Click the Create New Fill or Adjustment Layer button at the bottom of the Layers panel

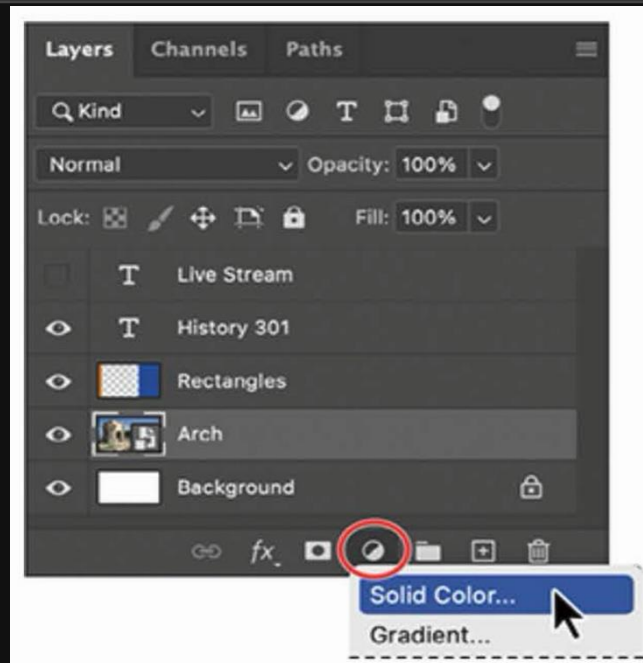
This is the half-filled circle icon at the very bottom of the Layers panel. A menu pops up with multiple options. Choose Solid Color from the top of the list.

3 In the Color Picker that opens, type 0c3303 in the # field — click OK

0c3303 is a very dark forest green. A new layer called Color Fill 1 appears in the Layers panel above Arch. The canvas turns solid green — do not worry, the next step fixes this.

4 Look at your Layers panel — you should see the Color Fill 1 layer with a colored square thumbnail and a white mask thumbnail

The white square is a layer mask — it controls where the color is visible. You will not edit the mask in this lesson, but it is there by default.



Layers panel — clicking Create New Fill Layer button, choosing Solid Color (PDF p.18, right column)

Set Hard Light Blend Mode — 90% Opacity — Hide Guides

5

With Color Fill 1 still selected, change the blend mode to Hard Light

Click the blending mode dropdown at the top-left of the Layers panel — currently says Normal. Choose Hard Light. The green no longer covers everything — the photo shows through with a green tint and stronger contrast. Hard Light blend mode multiplies dark tones and screens light tones, increasing overall contrast and shadow depth while letting the image show through.

6

Change the Opacity value to 90%

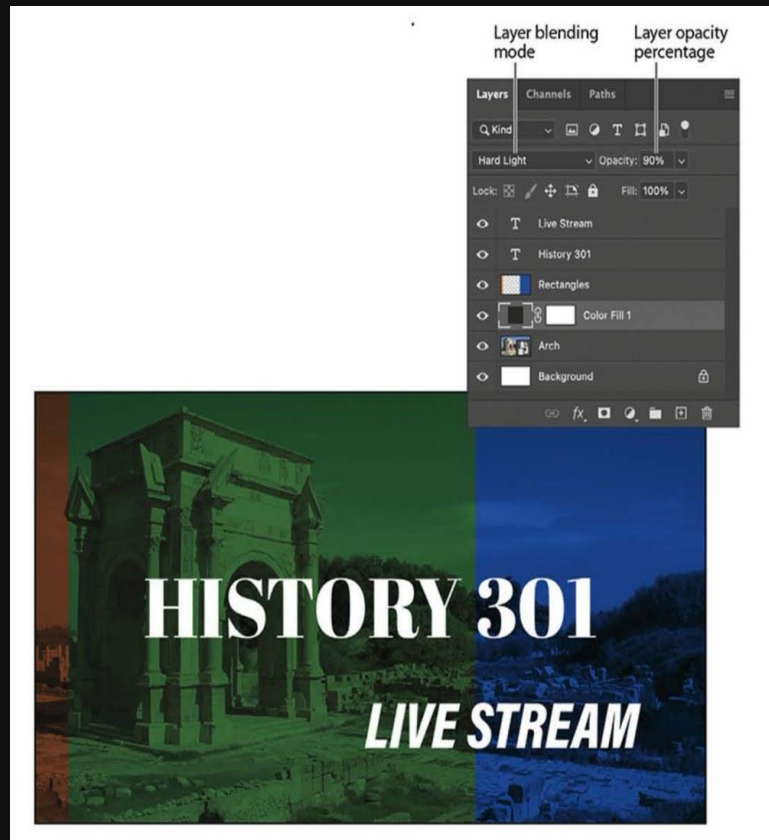
The Opacity field is at the top-right of the Layers panel, right next to the blend mode. Click on it and type 90, then press Enter. Dropping to 90% lets just a hint of the original photo's tone come through the green, making the result feel more natural and less like a flat color overlay.

7

Choose View > Show > Guides to hide the cyan guide lines

The cyan guide lines were there to help you place elements inside the safe zone. Now that your design is taking shape, hiding them lets you see the composition more clearly. Guides are non-destructive — they do not print or export.

📌 At this point your Layers panel (from top to bottom) should read:
Live Stream | History 301 | Rectangles | Color Fill 1 | Arch |
Background



Canvas + Layers panel — Hard Light blend, 90% opacity, full layer stack visible

Sample a Color for Painting — Eyedropper Tool

Before you paint the spatter brush effect, you need to set the foreground color to the blue that matches the right side of your canvas. You could type a hex code — but a faster and more precise method is to sample a color directly from the canvas using the Eyedropper tool. Sampling reads the exact pixel color at the point you click.

1

Select the Eyedropper tool — press I or click it in the Tools panel

The Eyedropper icon looks like a dropper/pipette.

2

Click on a lighter blue area in the right side of your canvas

As soon as you click, that color is loaded as the foreground color. You can see it update in the foreground color swatch at the bottom of the Tools panel (the square in the lower-left, overlapping the background color square).

3

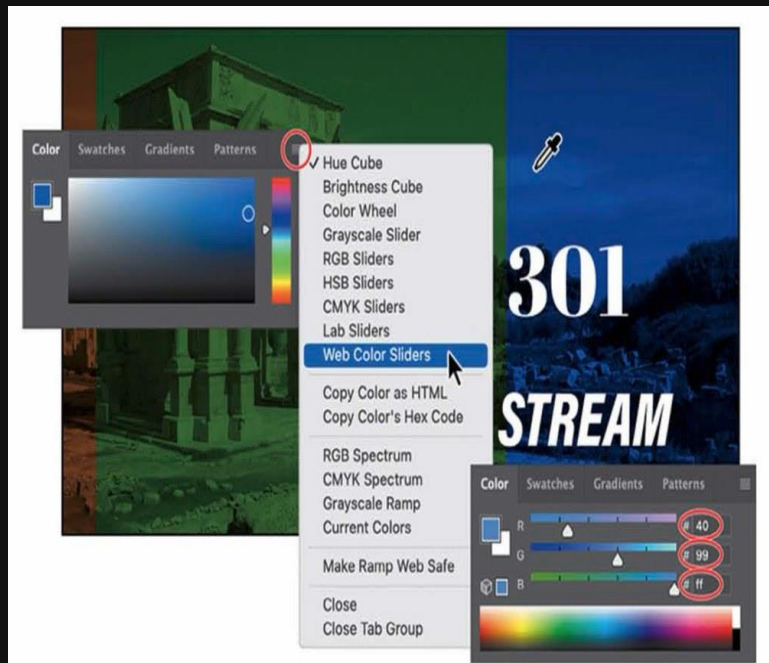
Open the Color panel — Window > Color

This opens the Color panel, which shows you the RGB values of the current foreground color. You need to brighten the sampled blue slightly for better contrast against the green-tinted image.

4

From the Color panel menu (≡ icon), choose Web Color Sliders

The panel switches to showing a hex code field. Type 4099ff and press Enter. This sets the foreground color to the exact bright blue you will use for painting.



Color panel showing Web Color Sliders with 4099ff blue value entered (PDF p.25, right column)

Create the Paint Layer and Choose the Brush

The paint effect needs its own layer — placed below the Live Stream text but above the Rectangles layer. You will use a specific spatter brush from the Special Effects Brushes group.

1 In the Layers panel, click the Rectangles layer to select it

The new Paint layer will be created directly above Rectangles — which is the position you need.

2 Hold Alt (Win) or Option (Mac) and click the Create a New Layer button

Holding Alt/Option while clicking the new layer button opens the New Layer dialog box first — so you can name the layer before it is created. Type Paint and click OK.

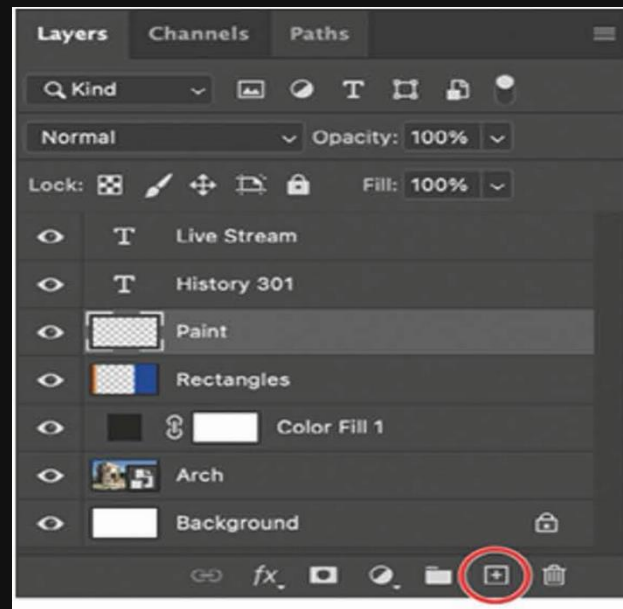
3 Select the Brush tool — press B or click the Brush icon in the Tools panel

4 Open the Brushes panel — Window > Brushes

The Brushes panel shows all available brush presets organized into groups.

5 Expand the Special Effects Brushes group — select Kyle's Spatter Brushes - Spatter Bot Tilt

Click the arrow next to Special Effects Brushes to expand the group. Click the first brush in the group — Kyle's Spatter Brushes - Spatter Bot Tilt — to select it. It creates a textured, paint-splatter-style stroke.



Layers panel showing Paint layer above Rectangles, Create New Layer button circled

Set Brush Size and Paint the Spatter Effect

6

Set the brush size to 80px in the options bar

In the options bar at the top, click the arrow next to the Brush Presets picker. Set the Size value to 80 px. Click away from the picker to close it. 80px gives a medium spatter spread — big enough to be visible but controlled enough to look intentional.

7

Position the brush over the word "Live" on the canvas

Make sure the Paint layer is still selected in the Layers panel. The paint will be applied to the Paint layer, not to the text or any other layer.

8

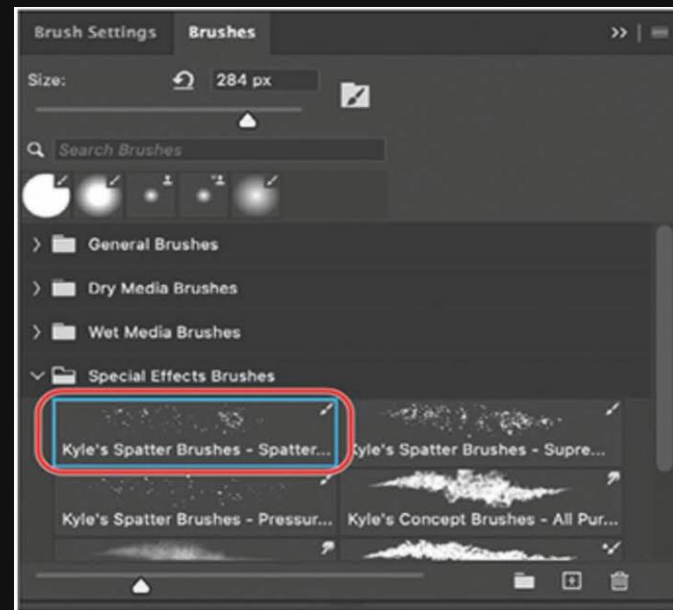
Click and drag in circular strokes over "Live" to build up the spatter

Do not make a single click. Drag in a circular, overlapping pattern to build up a concentrated area of spatter paint. The goal is a textured blue spot that sits behind the word LIVE and adds visual emphasis. The Paint layer is behind the Live Stream text layer in the stack, so the text always reads on top of the paint effect.

9

File > Save — Ctrl+S / Cmd+S

Save your progress.



Brushes panel — Special Effects Brushes expanded, Kyle's Spatter Brushes - Spatter Bot Tilt selected



Undo Tip: If your brush strokes don't look right, use Ctrl+Z (Win) / Cmd+Z (Mac) to undo one step at a time. Or use Edit > Toggle Last State (Ctrl+Alt+Z / Cmd+Option+Z) to quickly compare before and after your last stroke.

Reposition the Arch Photo — Move Tool

The composition right now has the Arch building sitting slightly too far to the left. Moving it to center creates a more balanced design — but moving it will reveal a transparent gap on the left edge of the canvas. You will fix that with Generative Fill in the next step.

1 Select the Move tool — press V

2 In the options bar, uncheck Auto-Select

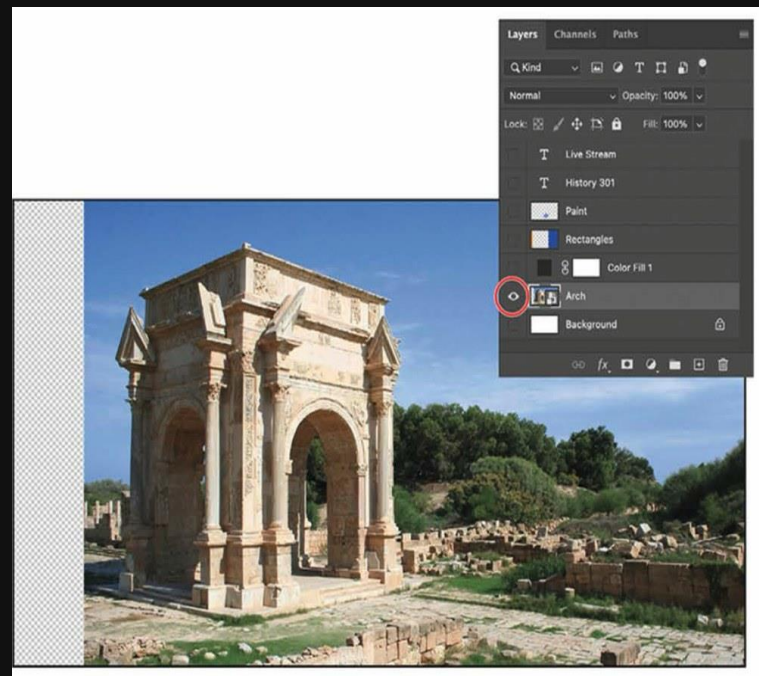
Auto-Select makes the Move tool automatically select whichever layer you click on the canvas. You need to turn it OFF because the Arch layer is behind other layers — if Auto-Select is on, you will accidentally select the wrong layer when you click. With it off, you control which layer is moved by selecting it manually in the Layers panel.

3 In the Layers panel, click the Arch layer to select it

Even with Auto-Select off you can still manually click any layer in the Layers panel to activate it.

4 Drag the Arch layer on the canvas until the building is centered in the green area

Click and drag anywhere on the canvas. The building moves. Slide it until the archway sits approximately in the center of the canvas horizontally. Smart Guides may appear as magenta lines to help align it.



Canvas after moving Arch layer — building centered, transparent gap visible on left edge

Fill the Gap — Generative Fill (AI-Powered)

Generative Fill is an AI-powered Photoshop feature that analyzes the existing image and generates new content to fill a selected area — matching the style, color, and detail of the surrounding pixels. It creates the content on its own Generative Fill layer, preserving your original Arch layer untouched.

1

Hold Alt (Win) / Option (Mac) and click the eye icon on the Arch layer in the Layers panel

This hides all other layers at once, leaving only the Arch layer visible. You can now clearly see the transparent (checkerboard) area on the left side of the canvas that needs to be filled.

2

Select the Rectangular Marquee tool (M) and drag to select the transparent gap

Drag from the left edge of the canvas to slightly overlap the left edge of the Arch photo layer. Overlap the Arch slightly — a few pixels — to ensure there will be no gap or seam between the generated content and the existing photo.

3

Make sure the Arch layer is selected in the Layers panel

Generative Fill will add its generated content directly above whichever layer is active. The Arch layer should already be selected.

4

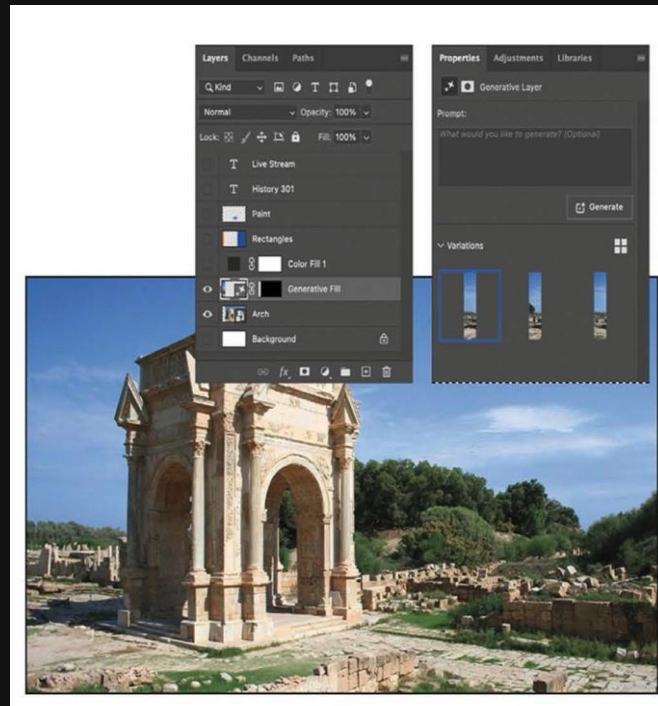
In the Contextual Task Bar, click Generative Fill, leave the prompt blank, click Generate

When the prompt appears, leave it empty. An empty prompt tells Photoshop to fill the selection with content that matches the existing image — in this case, more of the stone ruins and landscape. Photoshop generates three Variations. If a message appears about agreeing to User Guidelines, click Agree.

5

In the Properties panel, click each variation and pick the best one

Three thumbnail options appear in the Variations section of the Properties panel. Click each one to preview it on the canvas. Choose the one that looks most natural and seamless.



Generative Fill result — Layers panel showing Generative Fill layer, Properties panel with Variations

Reveal All Layers — Check the Final Composition

6

Right-click (Win) / Control-click (Mac) the eye icon on the Generative Fill layer in the Layers panel — choose Show/Hide All Other Layers

This turns all your other layers back on at once. You can now see the full composition: the centered Arch photo, the extended content on the left, the orange and blue color bars, the dark green overlay, both text layers, and the paint spatter effect behind LIVE STREAM.



Your final Layers panel order (top to bottom) should now be:

Live Stream | History 301 | Paint | Rectangles | Color Fill 1 | Generative Fill | Arch | Background

7

Review your composition — does anything need adjusting?

Look at the canvas carefully. Check that the text is readable, the color bars frame the design, and the Generative Fill content blends naturally. If anything looks off, now is the time to fix it before you export.

8

File > Save — Ctrl+S / Cmd+S

Save your .psd file. This is your master working file. Keep it safe — it contains all your editable layers.



Export a Copy for Delivery — File > Export As

Your .psd file is your master file — you never deliver that to a client or upload it to a streaming service. You need to export a flattened copy in a web-ready format. For this lesson, the target is a streaming service that requires: at least 1280 × 720 pixels, JPEG or PNG format, and under 2MB file size.

1

Choose File > Export > Export As

The Export As dialog opens. It has three panes: left (filename, scale, format list), center (preview of the exported image), and right (all the export settings).

2

Right pane — File Settings: set Format to JPG, Quality to 6

JPEG (JPG) is the standard format for photographic images delivered to the web, video, and streaming platforms. Quality 6 out of 12 gives a good balance of image quality and small file size.

3

Right pane — Image Size: set Width to 1280 and press Tab

Pressing Tab applies the value and automatically calculates the Height. Because the image is 1920 × 1080, scaling to 1280 width proportionally gives exactly 720 pixels tall. This is the 720p HD video standard.

4

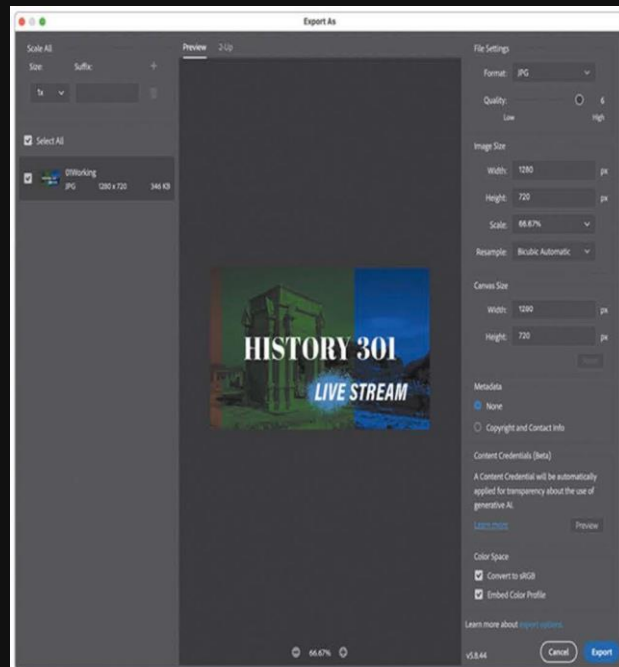
Right pane — Color Space: confirm Convert to sRGB and Embed Color Profile are both checked

sRGB is the standard color space for screens, web, and video. Embedding the color profile ensures colors look consistent across different monitors and devices even if they are calibrated differently.

5

Click Export — navigate to your Lesson01 folder — click Save

The exported file is named 01Working.jpg automatically. Check the left pane before clicking Export — it should confirm 1280 × 720, JPG, and a file size well under 2MB (typically around 300-400KB).



Export As dialog — JPG format, Width 1280, Height 720, Convert to sRGB checked

Quick Reference — Undo, Shortcuts, Final Layer Order

Undo Commands

Ctrl + Z / Cmd + Z

Undo one step at a time

Ctrl + Shift + Z / Cmd + Shift + Z

Redo — restore an undone step

Ctrl + Alt + Z / Cmd + Option + Z

Toggle Last State — quickly compare before and after

Window > History

Open History panel — see and jump to any previous state

Key Tool Shortcuts

V

Move tool

T

Horizontal Type

I

Eyedropper

Ctrl/Cmd + S

Save

M

Rectangular Marquee

B

Brush tool

Z

Zoom tool

Ctrl/Cmd + D

Deselect

Final Layer Order (top to bottom)

Live Stream	Type layer	Right-aligned, 165pt, Condensed font, All Caps
History 301	Type layer	Center-aligned, 210pt, All Caps
Paint	Pixel layer	Spatter brush effect, foreground color 4099ff blue
Rectangles	Pixel layer — Color blend mode	Orange 96px left bar + Blue 660px right bar
Color Fill 1	Solid Color Fill layer — Hard Light blend, 90% opacity	Dark green hex 0c3303
Generative Fill	AI-generated pixel layer	Fills the gap left of the Arch photo
Arch	Smart Object (Place Embedded)	The original Arch.jpg photo
Background	Background layer (locked)	White, created automatically with the document